that the industry finally acted on the mistakes it had been making post-pandemic. Bollywood, he says, was guilty of making "verbose films that didn't add value in the theatrical medium" post-pandemic. The theatrical industry was one of the last to bounce back from the blows of Covid-19. In its absence, the Hindi moviegoer embraced titles from the South, like *RRR*, *K.G.F: Chapter 2*, and *Kantara*, to get his entertainment fix. "Telling a tale is not enough. It has to be cinematic, a collective viewing experience and must evoke an emotion," says Rathi. "We finally learned to be more expressive on the big screen."

The first film this year to tick these boxes was *Pathaan*, which also marked Shah Rukh Khan's return to the big screen after four years. The YRF action entertainer went on to beat *Dangal* (2016) to become the highest grossing Hindi film and then surpassed the collections of Hindi-dubbed *Bahubali 2* (2017). Viral clips of audiences in movie theatre aisles grooving to the *Pathaan* track 'Jhoome Jo Pathaan' or whistling to Salman Khan's stylish cameo in the film were proof that the Indian cinema-viewing experience was back, and with a loud bang.



Tiger 3 *(already in cinemas)*

Salman Khan registered the biggest opening of his career with the third part of the *Tiger* spy franchise grossing Rs 43 crore in Hindi. Without doubt, Shah Rukh Khan's cameo as Pathaan and the subsequent banter between the two actors was the highlight of the film

Khan wasn't the only actor who rallied audiences back to the cinemas. Sunny Deol, at 66, embarked on a herculean mission to bring his son back from Pakistan in part two of the now over-two-decades-old blockbuster, *Gadar*. Nostalgia, in addition to the film's messaging of bash-thy-neighbour, resonated with the audiences who cheered for its patriotic, family man of a hero. Ranveer Singh, Pankaj Tripathi and Ayushmann Khurrana also contributed to the lush period with hits in *Rocky aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani*, *OMG 2* and *Dream Girl 2*, respectively.

Rathi, though, also notes that a film's scale or its star power isn't always the determining factor to bring audiences together. The success of *The Kerala Story*, which collected Rs 220 crore at the box office, highlighted how a serious subject can hit a nerve. Directed by Sudipto Sen, it is about the conversion of a few Hindu women to Islam and their subsequent indoctrination into ISIS, and plays on the 'love jihad' theme popular in Hindutva narratives.

Perhaps the biggest lesson for the industry from 2023 is to value the art of collaboration. Nowhere was it more evident as in *Jawan*, which saw Shah Rukh Khan rope in the best of talent from South India—on and off screen—for a film that managed to resonate with audiences nationwide. The presence of filmmaker Atlee, actors Nayanthara and Vijay Sethupathi and composer Anirudh Ravichander saw *Jawan* become the highest-grossing Hindi film in southern territories with gross collections of Rs 94 crore in Tamil and Telugu. For Atlee, who shifted base from Chennai

Box office collections are only expected to grow. In fact, multiplex giant PVR Inox will likely have added 150 screens by the end of this fiscal year